

The MISQ Paper:

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Warm-up Questions:

1. What inspired you to investigate the "braggart's dilemma" in the context of prosocial disclosures on social media? Was there a specific event or observation that sparked this research interest?

[Authors] Our interest in investigating the "braggart's dilemma" in the context of prosocial disclosures on social media was sparked by the innovative mobile application Charity Miles. This app allows users to transform their walking, biking, and running activities into charitable donations, which we found to be a groundbreaking model for engaging people in philanthropy. Intrigued by the potential of this model, we decided to delve deeper by collecting social media data related to Charity Miles and reaching out to Gene Gurkoff, the CEO of Charity Miles, for further insights.

During our conversation, Gene highlighted the critical role of social sharing, mentioning that while a significant portion of their users share their charitable activities on Twitter, they hoped to see even more sharing. This observation reinforced our belief in the powerful role of self-disclosure on social media—not just in sharing individual charitable acts but also in amplifying the overall momentum for giving. This insight served as a primary motivation for our focus on the braggart's dilemma.

2. The study uses the Charity Miles app as a compelling case. Were there other platforms or campaigns that you considered using as examples? What were the key factors that led to focusing on Charity Miles?

[Authors] Two key factors led us to focus on Charity Miles as the context for our study. First, Charity Miles offers a unique social sharing template that includes the number of miles and the type of exercise (e.g., “I biked 15.251 @CharityMiles for @EveryMomCounts.”). This feature allowed us to explicitly measure participants' effort levels, which was crucial for our analysis. Second, the template's evolution to include a thank-you note to sponsors (e.g., “Thx2 @GNC for

sponsoring me!”) provided an additional identifying source to understand what makes an effective social media sharing template. Regarding your question about other platforms, in general, any fundraising campaign that encourages donors to share their good deeds and spread the word about the cause on social media would have been relevant. For instance, campaigns from Facebook Fundraisers and GoFundMe also emphasize the importance of self-disclosure in prosocial behavior on social media. However, Charity Miles stood out because of its unique features, which allowed us to identify the mechanisms related to effort levels and the impact of sponsor acknowledgments.

Questions on Concepts, Methods, & Framework:

3. In your research, you employed a mixed methods approach across the four studies to allow them to complement one another. Could you elaborate on how this approach helped mitigate bias and refine the results, ultimately leading to the identification of deeper insights?

[Authors] A mixed methods approach is particularly valuable when exploring new phenomena or technologies, as it allows for a more comprehensive understanding by combining the strengths of both quantitative and qualitative methods. In our research, we employed two empirical analyses and two lab experiments. The empirical analyses provided insights into the effects of effort levels and changes in the social media message templates used by Charity Miles. However, these analyses were inherently limited by the constraints of Charity Miles's template design, which dictated how charity exercises were shared. To address this limitation and uncover the underlying reasons for the observed increase in likes, we conducted a lab experiment. This experiment revealed that the increase in likes was primarily driven by expressing gratitude toward other contributors, while simply mentioning a third-party contributor could decrease likes. Furthermore, our initial empirical analyses focused only on sponsors with good reputations. To ensure the robustness of our findings, we conducted a second lab experiment that extended our investigation to sponsors with bad reputations. This experiment confirmed that the positive effects of expressing gratitude persisted even when the sponsor had a bad reputation, thus deepening our understanding of our conclusions.

4. *Could you elaborate on the potential psychological mechanisms that might explain why expressing gratitude, even towards a sponsor with a bad reputation, has a positive effect? In addition, how you determine the degree of thanking a sponsor with a good reputation led to more likes than thanking a sponsor with a bad reputation.*

[Authors] When expressing gratitude towards a sponsor with a bad reputation, there are two competing mechanisms at play. On the one hand, expressing gratitude generally has a positive effect because it can make the individual appear less self-promotional and more altruistic. On the other hand, endorsing a sponsor with a bad reputation mitigates such an impact, as it might be perceived as supporting the sponsor's controversial standing. In our analysis, we observed that while both effects are present, the positive impact of expressing gratitude tends to outweigh the negative (moderation) effect of the sponsor's bad reputation, resulting in an overall positive effect.

To address your second question, we conducted a moderation analysis that allowed us to compare the impact of thanking sponsors with good versus bad reputations. This analysis provided an estimate of the average number of likes for each scenario, confirming that sponsors with good reputations generally receive more likes when gratitude is expressed, but the effect is still positive, although weaker, for sponsors with bad reputations.

5. *Your article draws on attribution theory, to develop a system of four hypotheses. Apart from attribution theory, what were the other candidate theories that you had initially explored from the extant literature, and how Attribution theory stood out from the rest to eventually setup-a-base for your work?*

[Authors] This is an excellent question. We chose attribution theory early in the process because it provided a cohesive theoretical framework that could support all four studies and effectively tie them together to address our research questions on self-disclosure of prosocial behavior. Attribution theory, which explores how individuals make causal inferences by attributing causes to events, has been applied in understanding social media content related to prosocial participation, making it an ideal fit for our study. While we considered other theories from the

literature, such as social exchange theory, attribution theory stood out because of its direct relevance to our focus on how people interpret and react to the self-disclosure of prosocial actions on social media.

Reflective Questions:

6. Could you share any unexpected challenges or interesting insights you encountered while conducting the four studies for this research article? Especially, any specific peer-review comments that made you re-think the core idea of the paper towards its present form?

[Authors] We’re glad you asked this question. Initially, our submission included two empirical analyses, and a lab experiment designed to mirror the empirical setting, primarily as a validation check. However, during the review process, we encountered challenges in mechanism identification that led us to rethink and restructure the paper. The review panel posed a thought-provoking question: Was the increase in likes driven by the mention of a third-party contributor or by the expression of gratitude? To address this, we added a new lab experiment that specifically delineates these two effects. Additionally, we incorporated the panel’s suggestion to investigate scenarios where the sponsor has a bad reputation, which added another layer of depth to our analysis. These changes not only enhanced the clarity and robustness of our findings but also provided new insights that significantly enriched our paper.

7. Looking back, is there a particular aspect of the research article that you now believe could have been approached or explained differently to enhance clarity or impact of the paper?

[Authors] We humbly believe we have done a decent job in clarity, thanks in large part to the invaluable feedback from the review panel. Moreover, their guidance was instrumental in refining our work and enhancing its impact. One particularly insightful suggestion from the review panel was to connect our findings to the recent changes on Twitter (now “X”), which significantly increased the relevance and timeliness of our study.

Questions with a special focus on young researchers:

8. How can young researchers in the field of behavioral social media analysis determine and select an optimal sample size when employing mixed method approaches similar to those used in your studies?

[Authors] We believe that employing a mixed-methods approach should not compromise the rigor of either the empirical or behavioral components of the research. In our study, we utilized a robust dataset, including 104,636 observations for the first empirical analysis and 9,687 observations for the second. For the behavioral analysis, we conducted lab experiments with 203 and 431 subjects, respectively. Determining an optimal sample size typically involves calculating it based on the expected effect size and desired statistical power. With the accessibility of online platforms like Prolific and Amazon Mechanical Turk, it's feasible—and often beneficial—to use larger sample sizes, which can enhance the reliability and generalizability of the findings.

9. What inspired you to collaborate on this research project, and what common thread sustained your teamwork throughout the writing process?

[Authors] Our collaboration on this research project was driven by our shared interests and complementary expertise. Lucy's research focuses on social media in healthcare, and she has collaborated with Alfonso on humanitarian operations research. Alfonso has an extensive background in fundraising through digital platforms, which closely aligns with the themes of this study. Jane has a long-standing interest in the role of social media in charitable fundraising, making this project a perfect fit for her research agenda. Despite being at three different institutions now, our collaboration began when we were all at the Kelley School of Business at Indiana University, and our common goals sustained our teamwork throughout the idea generation, paper writing, and revision processes.

10. What advice would you give to aspiring researchers interested in studying social media and user behavior, particularly in the realm of prosocial actions and would be doing field experiments for the first time?

[Authors] We believe that the study of prosocial behavior on social media is an underexplored yet vital area of research, particularly for fostering a more humane and connected society. This emerging field holds significant promise, drawing deeply from the literature in public economics and social psychology. For aspiring researchers, especially those conducting field experiments for the first time, a thorough grounding in the existing literature is crucial—not only in terms of research methods but also in identifying meaningful research questions. This foundation will help ensure that your work contributes original and robust insights to the field.